

This project was for a Special Topics in Global Health class that focused on Non-Governmental Organizations in which we created our own Global Health NGO.



Demographic

Houselessness disproportionately affects queer youth. As of 2018, despite only 4% of Minnesotans identifying as LGBTQ+, 11% of unhoused Minnesotans are LGBTQ+; out of all unhoused youth in Minnesota (ages 24 and younger), 23% identify as LGBTQ+ (“People Who Identify as LGBTQ”). Based on responses from the Wilder Foundation’s Minnesota Homeless Study, queer unhoused Minnesotans experience higher rates of being victims of abuse than non-queer unhoused Minnesotans (“People Who Identify as LGBTQ”). In San Francisco, California, unhoused queer youth experience greater quantity and variety of substance use than their non-queer counterparts, and they also face more depressive symptoms, increased suicidal ideation, and higher rates of post-traumatic stress disorder (Hao). Among unhoused queer youth, ethnographic fieldwork conducted in central Texas found that those who are transgender “experience bullying, family rejection, and physical and sexual abuse at higher rates than LGBTQ youth experiencing [house]lessness” (Robinson). Despite those data originating from states other than Minnesota, it is highly likely that those rates are relatively similar to those in Minnesota.

However, when comparing rates among demographics, it is incredibly important to be sensitive to compound discrimination. 78% of the respondents in the San Francisco study identify as people of color—those respondents are therefore highly likely to face more challenges than the rest of the respondents, and the challenges they do share are likely to be exacerbated due their race. LGBTQ+ people generally face more mental health issues due to marginalization; people of color generally face more mental health issues due to marginalization; unhoused people generally face more mental health issues due to marginalization—these are just some of the potential compounding minority stressors an individual may face. For an NGO like OUTreach that values close-knit community, ethnographic research is essential to this sensitivity—an emphasis on “participant observation fieldwork during which the researcher engages with people as intensely as possible, sharing their lives and conversing with them in an open-ended way” ensures that needs of all voices are being identified and properly addressed while involving the NGO directly with the community it serves (Lewis, Ch. 7).

Goals and Objectives

With that emphasis on sensitivity to differences and intersectionality within the queer community in mind, especially of those who are unhoused, it is crucial to recognize that people working both with OUTreach—both internally and externally—may have different ideas and visions as well as ideas for management. Many NGOs “seek to build, and put in place, ways of working that can reflect, and are appropriate to, the values of strengthening social justice and achieving poverty reduction”—it is vital for individuals associated with OUTreach to maintain a willingness to listen to everyone’s input and be open to new ways to evolve if those values are to be upheld (Lewis, Ch. 8). OUTreach’s goals and objectives are straightforward: inform unhoused

queer youth in the Twin Cities about resources that can help them (whether that be gender affirming care, education, mental health services, shelters, support for those struggling with substance, etc.); facilitate the accessing, enrollment in, and/or delivery of those services; and connect unhoused queer youth with each other to build community. The starting goal for informing unhoused queer youth will be to reach 40% of the unhoused queer youth population in the Twin Cities, and to raise that goal by 15% each year until 100% is reached (measured via accessing the Twin Cities' most recent population demographic statistics and comparing them to OUTreach statistics). The starting goal for the facilitation of those services will be to facilitate access to one or more resources for 80% of those who were reached out to within that year, and raise that goal by 5% until 100% is reached (measured via comparing OUTreach statistics). The starting goal for connecting unhoused queer youth with one another to form a sense of strong community will be 15% feeling somewhat more connected, and 30% feeling much more connected (measured via survey with response options of "1 – I do not feel more connected, 2 – I feel somewhat more connected, 3 – I feel much more connected"); this survey will be distributed among those who interacted with the organization (interaction defined by communication and/or use of facilitation services), distributed at centers relating to unhoused queer youth, and advertised on social media (with the first option asking about whether or not the respondent has interacted with OUTreach).

Programs and Interventions

All of the goals and objectives mentioned will be achieved through programs and interventions categorized into short-term and long-term goals. It is worth emphasizing that OUTreach finds individual empowerment to be of great importance. Where "NGO 'contracting'

cultures have taken root”, citizens sometimes lose the ability to pressure governments for the improvement of public services, and instead “become dependent upon NGO intermediaries and the international donors that fund them” (Lewis, Ch. 9). OUTreach focuses on informing individuals and easing access, ensuring that individuals feel capable of seeking resources themselves so that they regain a sense of control of their life, intentionally avoiding the risk of becoming reliant on the NGO.

Short-term

One of the most essential programs to build a solid foundation and begin making a positive impact is the establishment of a strong social media presence. A majority of youth in the United States use social media, and in my personal experience and from what I have heard from my queer peers, social media is often used by queer youth as a safe space to find others who are like them and learn more about their community. By establishing a social media presence—especially on Instagram—among queer youth who use social media, it is reasonable to expect that a significant percentage of queer youth will at least know of OUTreach’s existence, and ideally know enough about it to use the services themselves, refer a friend, or even keep it in mind if they are not currently unhoused but expect to be in the future (or if they are in an unsafe living environment and are looking for LGBT-friendly resources to help them). Another method of outreach is partnering with local schools, especially middle and high schools. Some schools are more LGBT-friendly than others, but ideally as many in-school student services (i.e. counseling centers) will be informed of OUTreach’s existence and provided with contact information as possible. Additionally, it is common for schools to establish student-led Gay-Straight Alliances (GSAs), so a strong social media presence lends itself to GSA-distributed

awareness of the organization. Another, albeit less effective form of spreading awareness is with flyers being posted throughout the Twin Cities wherever allowed (prioritizing queer-, youth-, and unhoused-related establishments). Of course, one of OUTreach's other main programs is facilitating access to services. This will be done through volunteers answering mailed letters, emails, phone calls, text messages, and social media messages and evaluating the needs of individuals contacting OUTreach, and from there developing a plan for those individuals and offering assistance (i.e. translations, filling out of forms, legal advice, etc.) when needed. Ideally, OUTreach will partner with existing local organizations to simplify this process by establishing the ability to refer individuals to organizations with even more direct assistance with applicable services. Some potential local organizations for these partnerships include the Minnesota Transgender Health Coalition, Rainbow Health Minnesota, the advocacy group OutFront Minnesota, and the Youth Services Network (which provides unhoused youth-specific resources). Ideally, OUTreach will also have established relations with trusted services that help youth in unsafe living situations to allow for immediate referrals, especially for emergency situations. Some of the more general, broad interventions OUTreach will conduct are community awareness and advocacy regarding both local and national politics relating to the LGBTQ+ community (especially any laws or policies relating to LGBTQ+ youth and/or unhoused youth), and donation drives (such as for clothes or non-perishable foods) for unhoused queer youth.

Long-term

A major obstacle that prevents individuals from receiving any form of medical care is a lack of health insurance. In the long-term, once OUTreach has established trust and respect through transparent accountability and successful fulfillment of promises, and donors and

funding have been acquired, OUTreach will ideally partner with insurance companies to provide coverage for emergency services, especially those relating to health. Another partnership that would be incredibly beneficial to the organization in the long-term is the Trevor Project, a large and well-known non-profit suicide prevention and crisis intervention organization for LGBTQ+ youth. This would not only ease access to LGBT-sensitive services relating to mental health crises, but would also establish national recognition and reputability for OUTreach as an organization. At that point, OUTreach would ideally be able to expand its reach, first within Minnesota, and then eventually nationally (though programs and interventions would likely fluctuate depending on their region in order to most accurately address the needs of other regions).



However, either before or despite such expansion, the most ambitious goal for OUTreach is to establish “OUTreach Café”, a coffee shop and bakery in the Twin Cities that serves as a safe space for unhoused LGBTQ+ youth. The reasoning behind deciding on a café as a safe space is simple: among younger LGBTQ+ generations, cafés and coffee shops are often regarded as queer spaces. In this safe, quiet, accepting environment, unhoused LGBTQ+ youth can eat and

drink for free, relax and socialize, and even use one of the five provided desktop computers (free wifi provided). Additionally, because of the overlap between the LGBTQ+ community and art, local queer artists (prioritizing those who are unhoused) will be highlighted at OUTreach Café monthly via prints and/or other art-showcasing goods being sold at the café, with 100% of those profits going directly to those artists. One local queer artist will also be commissioned each year (always a different artist each year) to paint a mural on the exterior of the café (ideally in late-summer to early fall, as the beginning of the year in Minnesota is dangerously cold outside).

Feasibility and Sustainability

“The concept of ‘social capital’, which generally refers to cross-cutting ties based on trust and reciprocity between organized individuals, has potentially useful implications for the ways NGOs manage community relationships...NGOs may aim to strengthen local organizational structures in the form of group building, and sections of communities may seek to organize themselves into membership NGOs.”

(Lewis, Ch. 10)

Is it feasible?

The LGBTQ+ community is, and has historically proven to be (i.e. lesbians banding together to care for gay and bisexual men who were dying of HIV/AIDS while the government ignored their suffering, even though gay men had a tendency to treat lesbians horribly—an extension of misogyny—prior to the crisis), a close-knit community that values helping one another, especially due to the prevalence of familial rejection fostering a reliance on community

over family (hence the importance of “found family” within the queer community). Because of this, it is relatively safe to assume that there will be a reliable and stable number of volunteers to maintain OUTreach, or at least once enough of a social media presence has been established.

Is it sustainable?

It is expected that over time, once OUTreach becomes more trusted and well-known, there will be a proportional increase in volunteering. Not only will queer adults likely give back to their community within the scope of the short-term, it is possible that queer individuals who were assisted by OUTreach will return to volunteer for the organization in the long-term. In this way, the organization sustains itself.

Budget and Funding

Many NGOs, often being reliant on government funding and/or donations, “view themselves as vulnerable...and therefore behave defensively”, including being “reluctant to face up to information that suggests a level of failure, since admitting failure may be perceived as likely to increase vulnerability” (Lewis, Ch. 11). Because of this, in addition to prioritizing transparency and accountability, OUTreach will be realistic about what is and what isn’t working in order to ensure wise management of resources and not getting overly and rather unrealistically ambitious (i.e. being careful to not establish OUTreach Café before it is financially advisable to do so).

Proposed funding/income

At first, OUTreach will be volunteer-based at first, the only costs being advertising, likely either paid for out of pocket or with a loan. There will be no income for the organization until fundraising is successful and/or donors are established. In the long-term, donations will become essential, though profits from OUTreach Café will cover both overhead costs and additional funding for programs.

Operating costs, long-term

With the minimum cost of living in the Twin Cities area (Anoka, Carver, Dakota, Hennepin, Ramsey, Scott, and Washington counties) being \$40,000 per year, OUTreach Café employees will be paid that amount in total, hourly wage fluctuating but always guaranteeing that yearly amount based on total number of employees to ensure that those who need a job have one (for example, if 5 employees can be working at a time, but there are 20 employees total, those employees will work 3.5 hours a day—a 17.5 hour work week—with a wage of \$46.00 per hour; if only 5 employees can be working at a time, but there are 30 employees total, those employees will work 2.3 hours a day—a 11.7 hour work week—with a wage of \$68.50 per hour). For a year with 10 employees, the total cost of employee wages come out to be \$400,000. For a year with 30 employees, the total cost of employee wages come out to be \$1,200,000. The yearly artist commission for the exterior (or interior) mural is estimated to be around \$5,000.

Overhead costs, short-term

The only overhead cost in the short-term is advertising, mainly on instagram. To reach 11,000-30,000 people ages 13-25 for 30 days, it costs \$300. To reach 78,000-210,000 people ages 13-25 for 30 days, it costs \$3,000. The annual costs for advertising are entirely dependent

on how effective it is (more effective decreasing necessity for advertising and therefore lowering costs), but a rough annual estimate on the lower end is \$3,600. The other method of advertising—flyers—is expected to be of no expense.

Overhead costs, long-term

Of course, establishing a brand-new coffee shop is a difficult task. Upfront costs (one-time purchases) are expected to be a total of \$32,000— \$2,500 for five lower-cost desktop computers, and about \$30,000 for the equipment needed to run a café (Georgiev). As for yearly overhead costs, rent is expected to range around \$30.00 per square foot per year, so for a space with 2,000 square feet, rent would be about \$60,000 yearly. Fortunately, coffee shops are popular—especially in large cities—so it is reasonable to expect a relatively steady income. If the café is open for 10 hours (8am-6pm), 7 days a week, with an average of 3 paying customers per hour, and an average of a \$12.00 purchase per customer, weekly income would be about \$2,520. With that average weekly income, and excluding two weeks for holiday breaks, annual income from café sales alone would be about \$126,000.

Profit

With total annual costs, the first year of OUTreach Café (assuming only about 10 employees) would cost \$497,000. For the years after that, assuming an average of 20 employees, the annual cost of OUTreach Café would be \$865,000. For that first year, profits would be -\$371,000 in the negative (assuming 3 customers per hour, as previously calculated). If there were to be an average of 5 customers per hour for the following years (assuming a proportional increase in awareness of the café's existence and rate of customers), an income of \$210,000

would mean profit would be -\$655,000 in the negative. This is obviously not feasible on its own, but OUTreach Café would not be established before stable funding and donations are obtained. Because OUTreach Café emphasizes providing liveable wages to unhoused queer youth, decreasing wages is not an option.

Overall Impact

“In Fowler and Malunga's (2010) overview, three important internal issues for NGOs are highlighted. First is the importance of achieving accountable and effective approaches that can take into account both careful planning and evaluation, and the capacity to learn and address complexity and uncertainty. Achieving this balance, or what they call ‘an organizational blend’ (p.6), is the key challenge for which there are ‘no rules’, meaning that improvisation remains key. Second is the search for revitalized NGO identities within civil society that are viable and credible beyond the world of aid, including in different ways the renewal of the various values of charity, social justice, activism and welfare to which the sector in all its diversity has its roots. Third is the need to ‘optimize the political economy’ of NGOs as organizations, in which there is increasing money available for certain activities and very little for others, leaving some organizations in expansion and others in a continual struggle to survive. Organizations will need to experiment with further alliances, localization and voluntarism if the NGO sector is to remain diverse and credible.”

(Lewis, Ch. 12)

OUTreach strives for a legacy that lives up to the beauty of the diversity and resiliency of the queer community. Because of this, having a significant positive impact is extremely important. Transparency, accountability, courage to admit failure, creativity and flexibility, and willingness to listen to all perspectives and ideas are all OUTreach values. Advocacy and the formation of alliances for the queer community are essential.

Short-term impact

One intended short-term impact of OUTreach is to increase the percentage of unhoused queer youth living in the Twin Cities who are utilizing local resources that help them improve their physical health, mental health, education, access to housing, and other necessities, especially for their health. Another intended short-term impact is to at least increase the awareness of these programs among unhoused queer youth in the Twin Cities.

Long-term impact

Being queer is often isolating, and experiencing houselessness only intensifies that feeling. One intended long-term impact of OUTreach is to improve a sense of community among unhoused queer youth in the Twin Cities, with the hope of both improving the quality of life of unhoused queer youth and empowering them both in their identity and their self-worth. Another intended long-term impact of OUTreach is to employ at least 30% of unhoused queer youth in the Twin Cities. While 100% is ideal, the feasibility of that will have to be determined in the future once OUTreach has been operating for a while. Hopefully OUTreach will inspire the establishment of similar organizations across the state and even the country, helping as many unhoused queer youth as possible.

**logo details: colors are the three colors from the first/original pride flag that are not in the pride flag we now see today*

- *“Support is just one heart away” refers to how OUTreach connects humans with humans who care, the “heart” belonging to the human who will help you connect to resources*
- *Locations that are certified affiliates with OUTreach will be marked with a blue heart on the door*

Works Cited

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